

OCEAN



RIVER

A FREE GUIDE FROM NEXT ERA TRAVEL

Ocean or River?

A calm way to decide which kind of cruise actually fits you.

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

The right cruise is the one that matches how you like to travel.

Ocean and river cruises are both wonderful, and they are very different experiences. People often compare them on price or itinerary first, then discover on board that the pace was not what they wanted.

This guide helps you decide in a different order. First how you like to spend a day, then the kind of ship that suits it, then the questions worth asking before you book.

> **How to use this guide.** Read the side by side on page three, then tick the statements on page four that sound like you. If one column wins clearly, you have your answer. If it is close, the questions that follow will help.

WHAT IS INSIDE

- ✓ Five questions about how you like to travel
- ✓ Ocean and river side by side
- ✓ Which one suits you: a short self check
- ✓ What to know about cabins
- ✓ Twelve questions to ask any cruise line
- ✓ The details around the sailing
- ✓ Mistakes I see most often

STEP ONE

Start with how you like to travel.

Answer these together or on your own, before you look at a single itinerary.

1. **What is a perfect day away?** A slow morning and a long lunch, a full day exploring on foot, or a mix of rest and activity with something to do every evening.
2. **How do you feel about crowds?** Some people love a lively ship. Others want quiet decks and a dining room where staff learn your name.
3. **Do you want one place or many?** Seeing several towns up close, or a few ports with long beach days and a lot of time on board.
4. **Who is coming?** Couples, friends, three generations, or a group with different energy levels. This changes what matters most.
5. **What would make you feel the trip was worth it?** Culture and history, food and wine, relaxation, or simply not having to plan every day.

> **Why this order works.** Once you know the pace and the kind of company you want, most of the choice is made. The itinerary becomes the fun part, not the deciding part.

STEP TWO

Ocean and river, side by side.

These are general patterns. Every cruise line is different, so use this as a starting point.

	OCEAN	RIVER
Ship size	Large, often carrying thousands of guests	Small, often fewer than two hundred guests
Feel	Lively, with a lot to choose from on board	Quiet, personal, and focused on the places you pass
Where you go	Coastlines and islands across several ports	Rivers and towns, often in the heart of the old town
Docking	Larger ports, sometimes a shuttle or taxi into town	Often within walking distance of what you came to see
On board	Many dining rooms, shows, pools, and activities	One dining room, lounge, and sun deck, with talks about the next stop
Cabins	Wide range, from interior to large suites	Fewer categories, many with a window or balcony
Motion	Open water can be rough on some days	Generally calm, and you are close to land
Inclusions	Varies widely, and extras add up	Often more included, such as some excursions or drinks, but it varies
Best for	Variety, families, beach days, a lively atmosphere	Culture, food and wine, slower travel, easy exploring

> **A note from me.** What is included differs a great deal between lines on both sides. Compare what you would actually use, not only the headline.

STEP THREE

Which one sounds like you?

Tick the statements that feel true. Count each column at the end.

OCEAN TENDS TO SUIT YOU IF

- ☐ You like having lots of choices every day, without planning them
- ☐ You want beach days, islands, and a lively ship
- ☐ You are traveling with a group that wants different things
- ☐ You enjoy entertainment and activities in the evening
- ☐ You are happy to rest on the ship between ports

RIVER TENDS TO SUIT YOU IF

- ☐ You would rather step off the ship and be in the middle of a town
- ☐ You prefer a quieter atmosphere and a smaller group of guests
- ☐ You are curious about history, food, wine, and local culture
- ☐ You like unpacking once and still seeing something new each morning
- ☐ You value a personal feel over a long list of onboard options

> **If it is close.** You can still choose well. Think about the last trip you truly enjoyed and what made it work. That usually settles it.

STEP FOUR

What to know about cabins.

The cabin is the one part of the trip you cannot upgrade once you are on board, so it is worth a little thought.

- ✓ **Think about how you will use it.** If you plan to spend quiet mornings or evenings in the room, a balcony or large window may be worth it. If you will be out all day, a simpler cabin can be perfectly good.
- ✓ **Check the location.** Cabins near lounges, kitchens, or machinery can be noisier. Ask where a category sits on the ship.
- ✓ **On rivers, ask about the balcony.** Some are true balconies, and some are windows that open. They are not the same.
- ✓ **On ocean ships, ask about motion.** Mid ship and lower decks tend to feel steadier for guests who are sensitive to movement.
- ✓ **Ask about accessibility early.** Cabin and ship layouts vary, and the right category can sell out first.

NOT SURE WHICH CATEGORY TO CHOOSE?

This is where a second opinion helps. I can tell you which categories are worth it on a specific ship and which are not.

STEP FIVE

Twelve questions to ask any cruise line.

Ask the same questions of each line so you can compare honestly, and keep the answers next to your five answers from step one.

- [ ] How many guests are on board, and how many crew?
- [ ] What is included in the fare, and what costs extra, such as drinks, excursions, and gratuities?
- [ ] Which shore excursions are included, and which are optional?
- [ ] Where does the ship dock, and how far is that from the town center?
- [ ] What are the cabin categories, and how do the details differ, such as balcony type and size?
- [ ] What is a typical day on board like, and how much free time do guests have?
- [ ] What dining options are there, and how are special diets handled?
- [ ] How is Wi-Fi, and is it included?
- [ ] What is the line's policy if water levels or weather change the itinerary?
- [ ] What are the payment schedule and the change and cancellation terms?
- [ ] What is the guest age and style, and is the line a good fit for our group?
- [ ] Are there arrival day and departure day details we should plan around?

AROUND THE SAILING

The details that make it feel easy.

The cruise itself is only part of the trip. A little planning around it makes the whole journey calmer.

- ✓ **Arrive a day early.** A flight delay should not mean missing the ship. A night in the embarkation city also lets you rest before you board.
- ✓ **Check flights against embarkation and disembarkation times.** Late flights on the last day are a common source of stress.
- ✓ **Think about a stay before or after.** Many river itineraries start and end in cities worth a couple of days on their own.
- ✓ **Confirm entry requirements early.** Passports, visas, and any health requirements can differ for each country on your route.
- ✓ **Consider travel protection.** Itineraries can change and trips can be interrupted. Ask what is covered before you buy.
- ✓ **Travelling with others?** Plan cabins, dining, and arrival times together so no one is left piecing it together.

THE MISTAKES I SEE MOST OFTEN

- ✓ Choosing by price alone, then finding the pace is not right
- ✓ Assuming "all inclusive" means the same on every line
- ✓ Booking the cheapest cabin, then wanting more time in it
- ✓ Leaving flights and hotels until last
- ✓ Not asking where the ship docks

YOUR NEXT STEP

If you would rather not decide alone.

This guide is a good start. Some travelers take it from here and choose with confidence. Others want someone to match the line, ship, and cabin to them, and to handle the flights, hotels, and details around the sailing.

That is the work I do. We begin with a consultation, where I listen to how you like to travel and who is coming. Your planning investment is quoted after our conversation, so there are no surprises.

Christine Joy

Next Era Travel
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This guide is general information to help you plan. Details, inclusions, and requirements change, so always confirm current information with official sources and your travel provider before you book.